After the Bates College talk, however, I no longer had dreams like that.

18

A more unusual event took place on February 5, 1950. In the company of three minor show-business people (one of whom had once corresponded with me), Gertrude and I went to the New College Inn, something that would now be referred to as a gay nightclub.

The entertainment was by men who were heavily made up, or in women's clothes, or both. It was very good and the men were very pretty. "Good heavens," I muttered to Gertrude, "I could almost believe I married the wrong sex."

Once was enough, however. My curiosity was sated. I have nothing against gays—may they live long and prosper; but I have never sought out such entertainment again.

*9

Reviews of Pebble in the Sky kept trickling in, and by and large they were favorable. Roy Machlowitz wrote a long letter in which he

pointed out numerous weaknesses in the book, and his wife, Eleanor, added a letter in which she mentioned weaknesses he had missed.

I found out at once that I was not one of those authors who welcomed "constructive criticism." I replied with a letter that clearly revealed, I am afraid, that I was not in the least grateful for the help they were giving me, and our friendship trickled to an end.

The Machlowitz letter came just as I was sending the first third of The Stars, like Dust— to Brad, and I didn't like having my confidence shaken in this way.

20

One of my Boston friends—a Gentile—dropped around on February 21, 1950. 5 He was apparently in a spot of financial trouble and needed $200.

Well aware that one routinely asks twice as much as one needs, expecting it to be cut in half, I pulled out my checkbook and offered him one hundred. He accepted gladly.